2.1 What is digital identity?

The quickest way to sidetrack any digital identity conversation is to ask, “But what’s identity?” Identity means different things depending on the context: legal, philosophical, technical, or social.

Philosophically, there are two broad traditions. Philosopher David Hume thought of identity as a bundle of attributes. Bundle theory puts attributes into a collection with little regard to what ties them together. As an example, you might identify an apple as red, spherical, 12 centimeters in diameter, and crisp. René Descartes thought bundle theory was mistaken, believing that identity must be tied to some underlying entity. His famous quote, “I think, therefore I am,” describes his philosophy, called *substance theory*, in a single memorable phrase.

While we can’t lose track of these philosophical underpinnings, for our purposes, we will need a much more functional definition of identity. *Digital identity allows systems to recognize, remember, and relate to people, organizations, things, services, and digital agents.* The ability to recognize, remember, and relate to another entity online is indispensable for digital interactions.

Digital identity is foundational to the security, personalization, and functionality of modern computing systems. Organizations use identity systems to support the specific kinds of relationships that they need to create with others. For example, it's not unusual for an organization to use a different identity system for employees than the one they use to support customers. Each of those relationships has specific needs and thus requires different systems to support them.

Identity powers policy-based access control and dynamic authorization. Authorization depends on who (or what) an entity is, what it does, and its relationships to other entities. In the context of dynamic authorization, the underlying identity system enables the authorization system to make decisions about access and permissions by providing the context for authorization.